



Cavalry charge near Brandy Station

On June 9, 1863 more than 19,000 cavalry clashed for 12 hours along the Rappahannock River in a surprise encounter. It resulted in a Southern victory, but alerted the Union to Lee's unexpected advance northward.

Testing times for Lee

Having extracted a promise from Stuart that he would quickly rejoin the main Confederate force, Lee agreed, and on June 25 he suddenly found himself without Stuart and his three best cavalry brigades. The cavalry chief had left Lee with just enough horsemen to screen the Southern army from Union cavalry probes, but not enough to provide him with a rapid scouting force for his infantry. The timing could not have been worse—the Confederate infantry had just begun crossing the Pennsylvania state line as his cavalry commander departed. Lee would be operationally blinded until Stuart returned from reconnaissance. For his part, Joseph Hooker refused to believe that Lee's initial movements represented another great raid. Rather, he rationalized that the enemy was simply trying